

Day 98 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Current Affairs in History & National Movement (8): Indian Inscriptions Discovered in Egypt's Valley of the Kings

READING MATERIAL

Covers a major 2026 archaeological discovery: ancient Indian-language inscriptions found in Egypt's Valley of the Kings, revealing a 2,000-year-old Indo-Egyptian connection.

Q: What was discovered in Egypt's Valley of the Kings, announced in February 2026?

A: Nearly 30 inscriptions in ancient Indian languages and scripts, found across 6 tombs.

Q: Which script/language do most of these inscriptions use, and which time period do they date to?

A: Most are in Tamil-Brahmi script (with some Sanskrit and other Indian-subcontinent scripts too) — dating to the 1st-3rd centuries AD (the Roman era).

Q: What do these inscriptions reveal about Indians in ancient Egypt?

A: That Indians from different regions of the subcontinent were present in Egypt during this period, integrated into Roman Egyptian society, while retaining awareness of a shared Indian cultural identity — one individual, 'Cikai Korran', left his name 8 times across 5 different tombs.

Q: Who announced this discovery, and where?

A: Charlotte Schmid (French School of Asian Studies, Paris) and Ingo Strauch (University of Lausanne), presented on 25 February 2026 at the International Conference on Tamil Epigraphy, held in Chennai.

Q: Why is this discovery significant?

A: It is the **FIRST** solid archaeological evidence of Indian visitors to the Nile Valley during the early Roman period — expanding known Indo-Egyptian connections beyond the previously-known coastal Red Sea settlements.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Nearly 30 ancient Indian-language inscriptions were discovered in Egypt's Valley of the Kings, across how many tombs?

- A. 3
- B. 6 ✓**
- C. 9
- D. 12

Explanation: 6 tombs. [medium, web-research]

2. Most of the inscriptions found in the Valley of the Kings are in which script?

- A. Devanagari
- B. Tamil-Brahmi ✓**
- C. Grantha
- D. Kharosthi

Explanation: Tamil-Brahmi. [medium, web-research]

3. These inscriptions date to which historical period?

- A. 1st-3rd centuries BC
- B. 1st-3rd centuries AD ✓**
- C. 5th-7th centuries AD
- D. 10th-12th centuries AD

Explanation: 1st-3rd centuries AD (Roman era). [medium, web-research]

4. This discovery was announced (25 February 2026) at which conference?

- A. World Tamil Conference
- B. International Conference on Tamil Epigraphy, Chennai ✓**
- C. UNESCO World Heritage Conference

D. Indian History Congress

Explanation: International Conference on Tamil Epigraphy, Chennai. [hard, web-research]

5. This discovery is significant because it provides the first solid archaeological evidence of Indian visitors to:

A. The Mediterranean coast

B. The Nile Valley during the early Roman period ✓

C. Mesopotamia

D. The Arabian Peninsula

Explanation: The Nile Valley during the early Roman period. [medium, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Percentage

READING MATERIAL

Percentage is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills. TNPSC's percentage questions are built from a handful of recurring shapes — successive discounts, reverse percentage ('20% of $x = 50$, find x '), percentage of a mixture, and percentage of a time period — recognize the shape first, then compute.

Q: Method — successive percentage discounts: A TV was sold for ₹14,400 after successive discounts of 10% and 20%. What was its original (market) price?

A: Successive discounts don't add (it's NOT a flat 30% off) — apply them one after another. If the market price is P : $P \times 0.90 \times 0.80 = 14,400 \rightarrow P \times 0.72 = 14,400 \rightarrow P = 14,400 / 0.72 = ₹20,000$.

Q: Method — percentage of a mixture (the parts must add to 100%): An alloy is 30% copper and 40% zinc, rest nickel. Find the nickel in 20 kg of the alloy.

A: Nickel % = $100 - 30 - 40 = 30\%$. Nickel amount = 30% of 20 kg = 6 kg. The key step is realizing the percentages must total 100% — nickel is whatever's left over, not a number given directly.

Q: Method — reverse percentage ('find the whole, given a percentage of it'): If 20% of $x = 50$, find x .

A: 20% of $x = 50 \rightarrow 0.20 \times x = 50 \rightarrow x = 50 / 0.20 = 250$. Reverse-percentage questions give you the part and the percentage, and ask for the whole — divide, don't multiply.

Q: Method — percentage of a decimal/small number: Find 0.75% of 40 kg.

A: $0.75\% = 0.0075$. $0.0075 \times 40 = 0.3$ kg. Common mistake: treating '0.75%' as '0.75' (i.e. 75%) instead of converting the decimal percentage properly — always convert to a decimal fraction first (divide by 100) before multiplying.

Q: Method — percentage of a time period: What percentage of a day is 10 hours?

A: A day = 24 hours. $10/24 \times 100 = 41.67\%$.

Q: Method — percentage of a fraction: What percent of $2/7$ is $1/35$?

A: Set up: $x\% \text{ of } (2/7) = 1/35 \rightarrow x/100 \times 2/7 = 1/35 \rightarrow x = (1/35) \times (7/2) \times 100 = (7/70) \times 100 = 10\%$.

Q: Method — sum of two independent percentage-of-number terms: Find the value of 28% of 450 + 45% of 280.

A: 28% of 450 = 126. 45% of 280 = 126. Sum = $126 + 126 = 252$. (A nice coincidence both terms equal 126 here — don't expect that in general, just add the two percentage values separately.)

Q: Method — percentage greater than 100% (the result is bigger than the original number): Find 280% of 3,940.

A: $280\% = 2.80$. $2.80 \times 3,940 = 11,032$. Percentages over 100% just mean the result is larger than the base number — the calculation method doesn't change.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. A mobile phone was sold for ₹10,200 after successive discounts of 15% and 20%. What was its original price?

- A. ₹14,500
- B. ₹15,000 ✓**
- C. ₹15,500
- D. ₹16,000

Explanation: $P \times 0.85 \times 0.80 = 10,200 \rightarrow P \times 0.68 = 10,200 \rightarrow P = 15,000$. [medium, authored]

2. An alloy is 25% tin and 35% lead, the rest is copper. Find the copper in 40 kg of the alloy.

- A. 10 kg
- B. 14 kg
- C. 16 kg ✓**
- D. 20 kg

Explanation: Copper % = $100 - 25 - 35 = 40\%$. 40% of 40 kg = 16 kg. [easy, authored]

3. If 35% of $y = 91$, find y .

- A. 230
- B. 250
- C. 260 ✓**

D. 240

Explanation: $y = 91 / 0.35 = 260$. [easy, authored]

4. Find 1.25% of 80 kg.

A. 1 kg ✓

B. 10 kg

C. 0.1 kg

D. 12.5 kg

Explanation: $1.25\% = 0.0125$. $0.0125 \times 80 = 1$ kg. [easy, authored]

5. What percentage of a day is 6 hours?

A. 20%

B. 25% ✓

C. 30%

D. 16.67%

Explanation: $6/24 \times 100 = 25\%$. [easy, authored]

6. What percent of $3/8$ is $3/40$?

A. 10%

B. 15%

C. 20% ✓

D. 12%

Explanation: $x\%$ of $(3/8) = 3/40$, so $x/100 = (3/40) \div (3/8) = (3/40) \times (8/3) = 1/5$, giving $x = 20\%$. [medium, authored]

7. Find the value of 32% of 350 + 18% of 200.

A. 148 ✓

B. 138

C. 150

D. 146

Explanation: 32% of 350 = 112. 18% of 200 = 36. Sum = 148. [medium, authored]

8. Find 320% of 2,500.

A. 7,500

B. 8,000 ✓

C. 8,500

D. 9,000

Explanation: $320\% = 3.2$. $3.2 \times 2,500 = 8,000$. [easy, authored]

9. A quantity is first increased by 20%, then decreased by 20%. What is the net percentage change?

A. No change

B. 4% decrease ✓

C. 4% increase

D. 20% decrease

Explanation: Net change after +20% then -20% is always a decrease of $(20 \times 20)/100 = 4\%$ — increasing and then decreasing by the same percentage never cancels out, because the second change applies to a different (larger) base. [hard, authored]

10. The price of an item increases from ₹250 to ₹300. What is the percentage increase?

A. 15%

B. 20% ✓

C. 25%

D. 30%

Explanation: Increase = 50. Percentage increase = $(50/250) \times 100 = 20\%$. [easy, authored]

Part C – General English: Poem: "On Killing a Tree" — Gieve Patel

READING MATERIAL

A poem arguing that truly killing a tree takes far more than a single cut — it requires destroying its root, the hidden source of its life. Real coaching-site evidence (after discarding one mismatched/wrong-poem question found on the source page) tests figure-of-speech identification on specific lines.

Q: What is the poem's central argument?

A: It takes much more effort to truly kill a tree than a single jab or cut. The tree has grown slowly, absorbing years of sunlight, air, and water — cutting and bruising it isn't enough, since it will heal and grow again. The root, hidden underground, must be exposed and fully destroyed for the tree to actually die.

Q: What is the deeper/metaphorical meaning some readings draw from the poem?

A: The poem can be read as being about confronting deep-seated feelings or habits — superficial treatment (a quick cut) doesn't resolve something with deep roots; only fully exposing and addressing the root cause truly 'kills' it.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "It has grown / Slowly consuming the earth."

A: Personification — the tree is given the active, almost intentional action of 'consuming' the earth, as though it were a living agent in pursuit of nourishment.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "leperous hide" (describing the tree's bark).

A: Metaphor — the bark is directly described as 'leperous hide' (skin), without 'like/as', comparing its rough, scarred texture to a disease-marked skin.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "The bleeding bark will heal."

A: Personification — the bark is described as capable of 'bleeding' and 'healing', human/animal-like properties applied to plant tissue.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "It is to be roped, tied, / And pulled out — snapped out / Or pulled out entirely."

A: Repetition — 'pulled out' is repeated, emphasizing the forceful, thorough effort needed to fully remove the root.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "Out of the anchoring earth."

A: Metaphor — the earth is described as 'anchoring', directly likening it to an anchor holding the root in place, without 'like/as'.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. According to the poem, what is required to TRULY kill a tree (not just cut it)?

- A. Burning its leaves
- B. A single deep cut
- C. Exposing and destroying its root ✓**
- D. Removing its fruit

Explanation: The root, hidden underground, must be exposed and destroyed — a cut alone allows the tree to heal and regrow. [medium, web-research]

2. "It has grown / Slowly consuming the earth" uses which figure of speech?

- A. Simile
- B. Metaphor
- C. Personification ✓**
- D. Hyperbole

Explanation: Personification — the tree given the active action of 'consuming'. [medium, web-research]

3. "Leperous hide" describing the tree's bark is an example of:

- A. Simile
- B. Metaphor ✓**
- C. Personification
- D. Alliteration

Explanation: Metaphor — bark directly described as diseased skin. [medium, web-research]

4. "The bleeding bark will heal" uses which figure of speech?

- A. Metaphor

B. Hyperbole

C. Personification ✓

D. Simile

Explanation: Personification — bark given the ability to 'bleed' and 'heal'. [medium, web-research]

5. The repeated phrase "pulled out" in the lines about the root is an example of:

A. Anaphora

B. Epistrophe

C. Repetition ✓

D. Alliteration

Explanation: Repetition — emphasizing the forceful effort needed. [medium, web-research]

6. "Out of the anchoring earth" uses which figure of speech?

A. Simile

B. Metaphor ✓

C. Personification

D. Alliteration

Explanation: Metaphor — earth described directly as 'anchoring'. [medium, web-research]